ENGLISH C1 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Tense and aspect viewpoint

Shift between event, process, completion and relevance by combining tense and aspect around a chosen viewpoint. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use tense and aspect viewpoint to present the same situation from different temporal perspectives without accidental contradiction while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Shift between event, process, completion and relevance by combining tense and aspect around a chosen viewpoint.

MODEL

By the time the review began, the team had been collecting data for months.

viewpoint time + perfect/non-perfect + progressive/non-progressive

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main tense and aspect viewpoint patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses present the same situation from different temporal perspectives without accidental contradiction.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in narrative, analysis, research reporting and retrospective commentary.

Build meaning before form

Shift between event, process, completion and relevance by combining tense and aspect around a chosen viewpoint.

What tense and aspect viewpoint communicates

Shift between event, process, completion and relevance by combining tense and aspect around a chosen viewpoint.

The central purpose is to present the same situation from different temporal perspectives without accidental contradiction. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The committee rejected the proposal in June.	a bounded event presented as a whole
The committee was considering the proposal when the leak occurred.	an event viewed from inside its unfolding process
The team had been collecting data for months before the review began.	duration viewed retrospectively from a later past point

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: viewpoint time + perfect/non-perfect + progressive/non-progressive. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “By the time the review began, the team had been collecting data for months.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Event viewpoint	simple aspect	The committee rejected the proposal in June.
Internal viewpoint	progressive aspect	The committee was considering the proposal when the leak occurred.
Retrospective viewpoint	perfect or perfect progressive	The team had been collecting data for months before the review began.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a bounded event presented as a whole	Event viewpoint
an event viewed from inside its unfolding process	Internal viewpoint
duration viewed retrospectively from a later past point	Retrospective viewpoint

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in narrative, analysis, research reporting and retrospective commentary. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03
viewpoint time	perfect/non-perfect	progressive/non-progressive

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: present the same situation from different temporal perspectives without accidental contradiction.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits narrative, analysis, research reporting and retrospective commentary.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Event viewpoint	simple aspect	The committee rejected the proposal in June.
Internal viewpoint	progressive aspect	The committee was considering the proposal when the leak occurred.
Retrospective viewpoint	perfect or perfect progressive	The team had been collecting data for months before the review began.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The committee rejected the proposal in June.	a bounded event presented as a whole
The committee was considering the proposal when the leak occurred.	an event viewed from inside its unfolding process
The team had been collecting data for months before the review began.	duration viewed retrospectively from a later past point

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use progressive aspect when completion is the essential claim.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use the progressive to imply completion.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not mix the reference point and event time inconsistently.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a bounded event presented as a whole?

OPTIONS The committee rejected the proposal in June. · The committee was considering the proposal when the leak occurred. · The team had been collecting data for months before the review began.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an event viewed from inside its unfolding process?

OPTIONS The committee was considering the proposal when the leak occurred. · The team had been collecting data for months before the review began. · The committee rejected the proposal in June.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: duration viewed retrospectively from a later past point?

OPTIONS The team had been collecting data for months before the review began. · The committee rejected the proposal in June. · The committee was considering the proposal when the leak occurred.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The committee rejected the proposal in June.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a bounded event presented as a whole · an event viewed from inside its unfolding process · duration viewed retrospectively from a later past point

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “The committee was considering the proposal when the leak occurred.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an event viewed from inside its unfolding process · duration viewed retrospectively from a later past point · a bounded event presented as a whole

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “The team had been collecting data for months before the review began.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS duration viewed retrospectively from a later past point · a bounded event presented as a whole · an event viewed from inside its unfolding process

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"The committee rejected the proposal in June." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Event viewpoint / Internal viewpoint / Retrospective viewpoint · Gap 2: a bounded event presented as a whole / an event viewed from inside its unfolding process / duration viewed retrospectively from a later past point

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"The committee was considering the proposal when the leak occurred." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Internal viewpoint / Retrospective viewpoint / Event viewpoint · Gap 2: an event viewed from inside its unfolding process / duration viewed retrospectively from a later past point / a bounded event presented as a whole

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"The team had been collecting data for months before the review began." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Retrospective viewpoint / Event viewpoint / Internal viewpoint · Gap 2: duration viewed retrospectively from a later past point / a bounded event presented as a whole / an event viewed from inside its unfolding process

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a bounded event presented as a whole: _____. Choose the model that expresses an event viewed from inside its unfolding process: _____. Choose the model that expresses duration viewed retrospectively from a later past point: _____. Choose the model built with simple aspect: _____. Choose the model built with progressive aspect: _____. Choose the model built with perfect or perfect progressive: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

The committee rejected the proposal in June. · The committee was considering the proposal when the leak occurred. · The team had been collecting data for months before the review began.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The committee _____ in June. The committee _____ the proposal when the leak occurred. The team _____ data for months before the review began. State the full structural pattern for Event viewpoint: _____. State the full structural pattern for Internal viewpoint: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The rejection is treated as one complete event.” using the Event viewpoint pattern to express a bounded event presented as a whole.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “Consideration was in progress at the time of the leak.” using the Internal viewpoint pattern to express an event viewed from inside its unfolding process.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “Data collection preceded and continued until the review.” using the Retrospective viewpoint pattern to express duration viewed retrospectively from a later past point.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The rejection is treated as one complete event.” using the Event viewpoint pattern to express a bounded event presented as a whole.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Event viewpoint to express a bounded event presented as a whole, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Internal viewpoint to express an event viewed from inside its unfolding process, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Retrospective viewpoint to express duration viewed retrospectively from a later past point, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The committee rejected the proposal in June.

Event viewpoint is the best match because a bounded event presented as a whole.

A2

The committee was considering the proposal when the leak occurred.

Internal viewpoint is the best match because an event viewed from inside its unfolding process.

A3

The team had been collecting data for months before the review began.

Retrospective viewpoint is the best match because duration viewed retrospectively from a later past point.

A4

a bounded event presented as a whole

The Event viewpoint pattern communicates a bounded event presented as a whole.

A5

an event viewed from inside its unfolding process

The Internal viewpoint pattern communicates an event viewed from inside its unfolding process.

A6

duration viewed retrospectively from a later past point

The Retrospective viewpoint pattern communicates duration viewed retrospectively from a later past point.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Event viewpoint / a bounded event presented as a whole

The structure belongs to the Event viewpoint pattern. Its communicative purpose is a bounded event presented as a whole.

B2

Internal viewpoint / an event viewed from inside its unfolding process

The structure belongs to the Internal viewpoint pattern. Its communicative purpose is an event viewed from inside its unfolding process.

B3

Retrospective viewpoint / duration viewed retrospectively from a later past point

The structure belongs to the Retrospective viewpoint pattern. Its communicative purpose is duration viewed retrospectively from a later past point.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The committee rejected the proposal in June.

Event viewpoint: simple aspect.

C2

The committee was considering the proposal when the leak occurred.

Internal viewpoint: progressive aspect.

C3

The team had been collecting data for months before the review began.

Retrospective viewpoint: perfect or perfect progressive.

C4

The committee rejected the proposal in June.

Event viewpoint: simple aspect.

C5

The committee was considering the proposal when the leak occurred.

Internal viewpoint: progressive aspect.

C6

The team had been collecting data for months before the review began.

Retrospective viewpoint: perfect or perfect progressive.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

rejected the proposal

Event viewpoint requires “rejected the proposal” in this model. simple aspect.

D2

was considering

Internal viewpoint requires “was considering” in this model. progressive aspect.

D3

had been collecting

Retrospective viewpoint requires “had been collecting” in this model. perfect or perfect progressive.

D4

simple aspect

Event viewpoint is built as simple aspect.

D5

progressive aspect

Internal viewpoint is built as progressive aspect.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The committee rejected the proposal in June.

simple aspect. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended event viewpoint effect.

E2

The committee was considering the proposal when the leak occurred.

progressive aspect. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended internal viewpoint effect.

E3

The team had been collecting data for months before the review began.

perfect or perfect progressive. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended retrospective viewpoint effect.

E4

The committee rejected the proposal in June.

simple aspect. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended event viewpoint effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The committee rejected the proposal in June. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses simple aspect accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

The committee was considering the proposal when the leak occurred. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses progressive aspect accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

The team had been collecting data for months before the review began. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses perfect or perfect progressive accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____